

Chapter 172-4

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Xu Qingzhu was very afraid that Liang Shi had been living in a fabricated dream all along.

That Qiu Zimin treated her badly was already an established fact that could be accepted. But if she were also being deceived by Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe, Liang Shi would probably be very hurt.

Fortunately, Liang Xinzhou was someone who could see things clearly and who genuinely cared for Liang Shi.

Liang Xinhe was also okay—though a bit soft-hearted, he wouldn't do anything bad to Liang Shi.

Moreover, because of Liang Xinran's appearance, Liang Xinhe had been even nicer to Liang Shi, occasionally buying things and sending them to the production crew, as if announcing to the entire crew—Liang Shi has backing!

It was actually rather cute.

During the filming of *Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo*, Liang Shi had also seen Liang Wanwan once.

She had cut her hair short and didn't mention Chen Mian at all, only saying she had won a national award and wanted to treat Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu to dinner.

They had Huaiyang cuisine for dinner—sweet-flavored.¹

However, after a few drinks, Liang Wanwan became tipsy. Afterward, she squatted alone on the Yujiang Bridge, holding onto the railing and gazing at the river.

Liang Shi was still too slow to notice, and it was only after Xu Qingzhu gave her a hint that she understood.

So Liang Wanwan liked Chen Mian.

But on the day Chen Mian asked her to pick up Liang Wanwan, they must have had a falling out.

Later, she heard that Chen Mian had stopped going to the media school altogether.

Chen Mian was actually a responsible person. Having agreed to do something for Gu Yixue, even when she was in bad shape and couldn't paint, she would lock herself at home and keep painting, ensuring she delivered the artwork to Gu Yixue on time.

But she heard that Chen Mian had abandoned that school project halfway through.

All because of Liang Wanwan.

Liang Shi didn't know what to say. She could only sigh that everyone was trapped in this besieged city of emotions, unable to escape.²

Not two days after *Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo* wrapped, *Journey of the Heart* began its promotional period.

Because this was Gu Yixue's first time entering the domestic market, it was also her first time following domestic promotional procedures.

Actually, according to domestic procedures, the pre-release buzz should have started a month before the movie's release, then theater scheduling would be determined based on audience expectations, and so on.

Gu Yixue was obviously late, but she hadn't planned on making much money from this movie anyway. It wasn't a commercial film to begin with.

With less than a week until release, the *Journey of the Heart* main creative team met again and began promotional screenings at various universities.

Because it was a work that had already been nominated for an international competition, people's standards were higher when evaluating it.

Yet in the rating systems of many strict and renowned film critics, it could score 8 points, which was considered very high.

Liang Shi's acting was also praised among them—she didn't just act on the surface, nor was she afraid to get her face dirty for the sake of her image. She played the role exactly as it should be, and even so, she didn't lose her aesthetic appeal. It was a rare kind of bone-structure beauty.

However, the flood of positive reviews online made audiences who hadn't yet seen the movie develop a rebellious attitude.

[This is all manufactured, right? Can you even trust movie bloggers these days?]

[Are you guys praising it just because you got paid? How good can someone's acting be in their first role?]

[As long as you pay them, will they even praise green-screen acting as amazing?]

[Seriously, can no one dig up Liang Shi's backer? This is fucking making me sick.]

[I strongly suspect she slept her way up through Quella.]

[If you want to criticize her, criticize her, but leave Quella out of it. A young prodigy director and screenwriter whose looks rival popular drama actresses—even if she were with Quella, that would be in the realm of romance, not sleeping one's way up.]

[.....]

Then somehow comments appeared saying that Quella and Liang Shi were in a secret relationship, and someone had even filmed videos of them drinking together and going to bars together.

They looked like they had a good relationship.

The movie hadn't even been released yet, and it had gotten another wave of attention because of Liang Shi alone.

Then the general public rebelled again.

[Is this some kind of celebrity? Does she have any notable works?]

[Honestly, the bar for your industry is way too low. You can get by just on looks?]

[Wasn't her red dress look just riding on Yang Shuyan's coattails? Someone who markets herself by clinging to various celebrities—can she be anything decent?]

[Isn't this movie an art film? It's trending every day—is the director that rich?]

[It's all to promote Liang Shi, right? Another fraud after YSY.]

[To the comment above, YYSY³, YSY actually has achievements. She shouldn't be compared to someone who's being hyped as a goddess based on just one set of photos and taking out loans to become a Best Actress. You're really elevating a fraud here.]

[So, don't you guys get penalized for using abbreviations? Can someone explain what all this stuff above means?]

[To be fair, Yang Shuyan.]

[.....]

After seeing all these chaotic comments, Gu Yixue sent the ridiculous screenshots to Liang Shi and asked in surprise: [Is the domestic film environment really like this now?]

Liang Shi: [...As you can see.]

Gu Yixue: [Since when do you have to dig into the actors and director before watching a movie?]

Liang Shi: [So when were we photographed?]

Gu Yixue: [Who knows.]

Liang Shi then asked Gu Yixue if she wanted to clarify.

She herself was used to this kind of thing in the domestic entertainment industry. She'd experienced even worse before.

So right now, she was operating on the principle of "if it's trending, it's free money."

If there was buzz, ride it. If there was a trending topic, latch onto it. Try to promote the movie without spending a cent. When dealing with Chen Liuying before, she had been thinking about hiring water armies, but now she couldn't be bothered to control anything.

Who needed water armies? Drama generated buzz.

Those film critics who had seen their movie and their fans were their free water army.

Liang Shi had already reported this matter to Xu Qingzhu, and Xu Qingzhu agreed, just telling her to handle it as she saw fit.

But Gu Yixue was also married, so she needed to consider Gu Yixue's situation too.

As it turned out, before Gu Yixue could even reply to her, she had already posted a clarification.

@Quella: Married. Do not disturb.

The person herself came out to refute the rumors.

And Liang Shi immediately reposted her Weibo:

@Liang Shi: Not with me. No need to speculate wildly.

Online, things finally quieted down briefly.

But unexpectedly, the third episode of *"Let's Go, Right Now"* and the release of *Journey of the Heart* were scheduled for the same day, just at different times.

Footnotes:

¹ **Huaiyang cuisine (淮揚菜):** One of the four major Chinese cuisines, originating from the Huai'an and Yangzhou regions of Jiangsu Province. It's known for its delicate, slightly sweet flavors and emphasis on fresh ingredients and precise knife work.

² **"Besieged city of emotions" (感情的圍城):** A reference to the famous Chinese novel "Fortress Besieged" (圍城) by Qian Zhongshu, which uses the metaphor of a besieged city to describe marriage and relationships—those outside want in, while those inside want out. Here it's used to describe being trapped in complicated emotional situations.

³ **"YYSY" (有一說一):** Chinese internet slang abbreviation meaning "to be fair" or "speaking objectively." The commenter is using abbreviations that confuse another user.